

CTF CHALLENGE

Miscellaneous · Medium Difficulty · 300 pts

Challenge Name	The Cartographer's Last Letter	Category	Miscellaneous
Difficulty	Medium (300 pts)	Flag Format	flag{...}
Author	Anonymous	Solves	0 / ∞

Challenge

■ PARTICIPANT INSTRUCTIONS

A cartographer vanished somewhere in the eastern desert. The only thing recovered was a fragment of his journal — five paragraphs, written in the hours before he disappeared.

Somewhere in this text, he has hidden a message for whoever finds the journal. Your task is to read the message, use it as a key, and decode the cipher string at the bottom of this page to recover the flag.

No external tools or lookups are required. **Everything you need is in this document.**

The Recovered Journal

He crossed the desert alone, carrying only a compass and the cartographer's worn journal, searching for the final map.

The old ruins stretched endlessly. Each dry wall told stories of civilizations swallowed whole by the sand.

Far beyond those ruins, ancient carvings marked something important. Those strange figures pointed northwest, toward territory unmarked. He understood why.

At dawn he saw each symbol clearly. By noon he ran each route faster. By dusk he sat and studied coordinates. At night he lay and read each notation.

Every explorer who truly wandered vast unmapped territories eventually accepts that silence itself speaks loudest.

Cartographer's Seal `ntio{bp3_u4x_v3d3z_t1ma}`

Hints

Hint 1 (-25 pts)

The cartographer was a man of structure. He organized his journal with precision — each paragraph a different length, each sentence carrying weight.

Hint 2 (-50 pts)

In the old telegraphers' code, brevity was everything. Short meant one thing. Long meant another.

Hint 3 (-75 pts)

The paragraph number tells you which word to inspect. The word's length tells you the signal. Group the signals by paragraph to spell a word. That word is a number.